

The Tortoise and the Hare

A one-shot adventure for **GURPS** Fourth Edition

One player and a GM · About 45 minutes · A 50-point hero

Introduction

Everybody knows how this race ends. Or do they? In this one-shot, the oldest race in the world is run again, and this time the dice decide. One player is the Tortoise: slow, stubborn and very hard to stop. The GM plays the Hare: the fastest animal in the meadow, and the first to say so.

The adventure is short. It fits in a lunch break, or opens a longer session. It needs one player, one GM, three six-sided dice and the **GURPS Basic Set**. New players learn Quick Contests and self-control rolls. Old hands can play it for the fun of a story that they think they know.

A Hare one day ridiculed the short feet and slow pace of the Tortoise, who replied, laughing: "Though you be swift as the wind, I will beat you in a race."

How to Use This Adventure

Read it once before you play. Give the player the Tortoise's stat block, or let the player build a Tortoise on 50 points. Then read "The Challenge" aloud, and play the race.

The Meadow

The meadow lies between the old oak and the mill pond. Rabbits, mice and a very old Fox live there. Nothing much happens in the meadow, and the animals like it that way. Then the Hare starts to boast.

The Challenge

Read aloud: "Under the old oak, the Hare stretches its long legs. 'Not one of you,' it says, 'could beat me from here to the mill pond.' The mice look away. The rabbits look at their feet. Then a slow voice comes from the grass: 'I could.'"

The Hare laughs so hard that it falls over. Then it accepts.

The Hare, believing her assertion to be simply impossible, assented to the proposal; and they agreed that the Fox should choose the course and fix the goal.

The Racers

The Tortoise

The Tortoise has a shell like a cobblestone and a will like a mule. It moves at a crawl, but it does not stop, and it does not tire.

The Tortoise (50 points)

ST 7 [-30]; DX 10 [0]; IQ 11 [20]; HT 13 [30].

HP 10 [6]; Will 13 [10]; Per 11 [0]; FP 13 [0].

Basic Speed 5.75 [0]; Basic Move 1 [-20]; Dodge 8.

SM -3; DR 3 (shell); thr 1d-3; sw 1d-2.

Advantages: Damage Resistance (Tough Shell) 3 [15]; Very Fit [15].

Disadvantages: Stubbornness [-5].

Quirks: Never hurries [-1].

Skills: Fast-Talk-11 [2]; Hiking-14 [4]; Running-14 [4].

The Hare

The Hare is the fastest animal in the meadow. It also has Overconfidence (p. B148): it cannot believe that it could lose.

The Hare (47 points)

ST 6 [-40]; DX 13 [60]; IQ 10 [0]; HT 11 [10].

HP 6 [0]; Will 10 [0]; Per 10 [0]; FP 11 [0].

Basic Speed 6.00 [0]; Basic Move 9 [15]; Dodge 9.

SM -2; DR 0; thr 1d-4; sw 1d-3.

Disadvantages: Overconfidence (12) [-5].

Quirks: Naps after lunch [-1].

Skills: Running-13 [8].

Attacks:

Kick (13): 1d-4 cr. Reach C.

The Course

The Fox walks the course and plants a feather at the goal. It is one mile long and has three landmarks.

- **The clover patch.** Halfway. The clover is sweet and the sun is warm. It is a very good place for a nap.

- **The hedge.** A thick hawthorn hedge with one small gap at the bottom. At SM -3, the Tortoise fits through the gap. At SM -2, the Hare does not, and must run around.
- **The mill pond.** The goal. The Fox waits there to judge the finish.

The Race

The Tortoise never for a moment stopped, but went on with a slow but steady pace straight to the end of the course.

Play the race in three steps.

1. **Taunt (optional).** At the start, the Tortoise can mock the Hare. Roll a Quick Contest (p. B348) of the Tortoise's Fast-Talk-11 against the Hare's Will of 10. If the Tortoise wins, the Hare takes -2 on its roll in step 2.
2. **The nap.** At the clover patch, the Hare is far ahead. The GM rolls 3d against the Hare's self-control number of 12 (p. B120). On a failure, the Hare lies down for a nap.
3. **The finish.** Roll a Quick Contest of Running (p. B218): the Tortoise's Running-14 against the Hare's Running-13. The Hare gets +4 for its speed, or -6 if it took a nap. If the player says that the Tortoise uses the gap in the hedge, the Tortoise gets +2. The winner reaches the pond first. On a tie, the Tortoise wins by the length of its nose.

The Hare, lying down by the wayside, fell fast asleep.

After the Race

If the Tortoise wins, the meadow cheers, and the Hare is quiet for a whole week. If the Hare wins, it boasts until the leaves fall. In both cases, give the player 1 character point.

Slow but steady wins the race.

Variations

- **More players.** Each extra player is another slow animal: a snail, a hedgehog or a mole. Each one rolls its own Quick Contest against the Hare.
- **A rematch.** The Hare has learned its lesson. It has no Overconfidence, so skip step 2. Can the Tortoise still win?

About This Adventure

Authors. Nathanael Farley and Claude. Nathanael Farley had the idea, directed the work and reviewed the result. Claude, an AI model by Anthropic (Claude Opus 5.5), drafted the text, the characters and the race rules, and typeset them. Made in October 2026.

Tools. Typeset with `Typst` and `gurps-ink` 0.1.0. The source of this adventure is `docs/example/tortoise-and-hare.typ` in the `gurps-ink` repository.

References.

- Aesop, “The Hare and the Tortoise”, in *Aesop’s Fables*, translated by George Fyler Townsend (1867). Public domain. The italic quotations come from this translation.
- ***GURPS Basic Set***, Fourth Edition, Steve Jackson Games. Rules cited: self-control rolls (p. B120), Overconfidence (p. B148), Running (p. B218), Quick Contests (p. B348).
- Steve Jackson Games, Online Policy: the disclaimer and the notice below.
- Steve Jackson Games, Authors’ Guidelines: Editorial Style: dice, book titles and page references.

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